Grace and Glorie

By Tom Ziegler

GRACE: (Pg 50) *(singing softly to herself*)* "He will give me grace and glory and go with me all the way."

GLORIA: (Pg 5-8) Hi. I'm Gloria Whitmore *(waiting for some recognition, getting none)* You probably don't remember, but we met briefly at the hospital last week.

GRACE: I remember. Wha'cha think, I'm senile?

GLORIA: No, of course not. Is there anyone here with you? Is your grandson here?

GRACE: Roy? He'll be back this evenin'. You need to talk to Roy?

GLORIA: You should have someone here with you – to care for you.

GRACE: Roy takes care of me. Cuts my fire wood, fetches me things from the IGA. I gotta pay him. Roy don't do nothin' for free.

GLORIA: I'm not here to talk to Roy, Mrs. Stiles, I'm here to see you. When you left the hospital this morning you forgot your medication. Here. *(taking a package from her bag)*

GRACE: You must think I'm a mighty forgetful ol' lady! Well, I'm not! Told the doctor I didn't want none o' that stuff. You people and your drugs. I've been doin' it your way for mor'n a year now, and all I can say is enough's enough!

INTRODUCTION

Two women -- Two lives that could not be more different. One is 90 years old. She is weathered by loss, sustained by faith, and preparing for the final chapter of her life. The other built a life of success in the city—educated, accomplished, and certain she understood how the world worked… until tragedy shattered everything she believed.

In a small farmhouse, surrounded by pain, memory, anger, and hope, two strangers confront questions that follow every life: Why do we suffer? What do we hold onto when everything is gone? And what does it mean to let go?

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GLORIA: *(a breath)* I'm a volunteer with an organization – it's called Hospice. Your doctor said he told you all about us.

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GRACE: Listen, honey, I don't mean to be unfriendly, but whatever it is you're sellin', I'm sure I'm way past needin' it. **(Pg 14)** Broke my hip last year. Had to go to the hospital. That's when they found the cancer. **(Pg 17)** I'm dying -- got a few weeks. Honey, when you're 90 years old, death don't come as no surprise. I buried my parents, my husband, and all of my five boys. If there's one thing I know about its death. You do this for a living, help people die?

GLORIA: Why are you making this seem so ridiculous? You know, you're a perfect example of what Hospice is all about! Your grandson, he picks you up from the hospital and dumps you here. You have no one to turn to for help. And believe me, Mrs. Stiles, you're going to need help!

GRACE: But I'm not alone. The good Lord's here with me.

GLORIA: Look, this hospice booklet. There are several stories in here about women just like you. Won't you at least read it?

GRACE: I don't think so. In the first place I'm not interested! In the second *(she can't read)* – we'll just stop with the first place.

GLORIA: Mrs Stiles, do you – You don't do you? My, God, that explains everything.

GRACE: Don't you have a family at home to take care of? Or a job. Thought all you young women nowadays had jobs!

GLORIA: I had a job in New York. I've looked for something around here, but there isn't anything – That's when I heard about this new hospice program, that they were desperate for volunteers with professional skills. I have an MBA from Harvard!

GRACE: Just tell me one thing. What do you get out of this?

GLORIA: Nothing! Okay, let's just say I'm interested in –

GRACE: Death? You can't even say the word.

GLORIA: Death. **(Pg 25)** And my name is Gloria. **(Pg 37)** [My] son. Danny. He was killed in an automobile accident a couple of years ago.

GRACE: These young people today and their automobiles. Why do they insist on driving so fast?

GLORIA: Danny was only twelve years old. He wasn't driving. I was.

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GRACE: Ter'ble thing to lose a child. My Carroll died when he was a baby. Went in to check on him one morning and he wasn't breathin'. Doctor come. Said these things just happen. Few years later Duane was out huntin' with his Daddy. Tripped over some barbed wire buried under the snow? Gun went off. He was 10 years old. Got so I hated to let the little ones out o' my sight. Thought I was goin' to lose 'em all. Guess I did, though, didn't I? Guess my only comfort is I'll be seein' 'em all real soon now.

GLORIA: Do you really believe that? About seein' your children in another life?

GRACE: Course I do, don't you?

GLORIA: I . . . No.

GRACE: S'pose next you're goin' to say you don't believe in God. **(Pg 50)** When I was just a girl, there was this hymn my Mama liked to sing. Called "Where He Leads Me." *(singing*)* "He will give me grace and glory, and go with me all the way." Mama used to laugh "We got our little Grace," she'd say. "Now all we need is a little Glorie." **(Pg 52)** *(irritably)* Why don't you go home?

GLORIA: I'm not leaving you here alone. Are you going to let me put you to bed?

GRACE: No! **(Pg 53)** I don't want to be asleep when He comes.

GLORIA: When who comes?

GRACE: Death. Oh, I'm afraid of Him, I am. But it's like this time my Daddy hauled us kids all the way to Richmond to the State Fair. They had this Ferris wheel there. Looked to be least a mile high. I wanted to ride that thing mor'n anything in the world, but I was too scared. My whole life's been like that. Always too scared. But this time I'm ready to be lifted up into that Promised Place *(breaking down)* where I won't hurt or be afraid ever again. *(Gloria goes to her but Grace, embarrassed pushes her away)*

GLORIA: **(Pg 55)** *(backing away)* Okay, okay.

GRACE: I regretted not havin' a daughter. Always felt I had so much to give, so many secrets to share. Boy children, they ain't interested in learnin' nothin'. All they want to do is break away. Get out and tear up the earth. You know I've always marveled the human race has been able to survive long as it has in the hands of men.

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GLORIA: You sound like a liberated woman, Grace. I'm impressed.

GRACE: Sure, I'm liberated all right. Ain't been mor'n fifty miles from this farm since the day I got married . . . *(quiet for a moment)* What I just said, 'bout boy children tearing up the earth? I wasn't talkin' 'bout your little boy. He wasn't like that, was he?

GLORIA: No.

GRACE: What was his name? Danny? *(Gloria nods)* Bet he was smart.

GLORIA: Yes. *(beat)* But he was still very much a boy. My husband saw to that. But for every jock thing Peter pushed Danny into, I insisted on equal time. Like with his piano. I mean he was only 12 years old and already developing his own style. He reminded me of – me when I was his age.

GRACE: Just look at your face. All lit up. Wondered if I'd ever see you smile like that.

GLORIA: Oh, Grace, that was such a time in my life. I had just moved to a very large [law] firm, brought in, I might add, as full partner. I finally had power, Grace. And money. I bought a car. An expensive car . . . *(tapers off, lost in thought; shakes it off and changes the subject)* Your children. The ones you lost when they were small. How did you deal with . . . losing them?

GRACE: Deal with it? I'm not sure I know what you mean. I grieved. Still do. But it was the good Lord's will.

GLORIA: And you didn't question it? The good Lord's will.

GRACE: What I don't think a person like you understands, people like us, people tied to the earth, we're used to death. You ***civilized*** people. You've moved so far away from death you forget it's as much a part of life as being born -- these things just happen.

GLORIA: *(moving away)* Oh yes, it certainly did happen. One warm, September afternoon

GRACE: Honey, don't –

GLORIA: . . . it had been Danny's first day at school. I decided to pick him up. In the ***new*** car. We were heading back across town. I don't know where it came from. The newspaper truck. When it hit us, we were pinned inside the wreck for more than an hour. Danny was on my lap. And as I held him, I could feel his life slowly slipping from his body. And there

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was nothing I could do. . . so we buried him. This gentle, gifted boy. Disposed of his clothes, his – things. And then, I just shut down. ouldn't go to work. Wouldn't answer the phone. Wouldn't even go outside. Peter dragged me from one doctor to another. We ended up with a shrink who suggested a change, somewhere far from the city. So now here I am . . . Okay, maybe I did deserve to get slapped down. I mean, I had become a little lofty, a little full of myself. But if these were my sins, ***MY SINS***, why was it Danny who paid for them? You talk about God? What kind of God is this? Look at your life. Haven't you ever asked yourself . . . *(stops. gropes for control)* I'm sorry. I don't know why I'm doing this.

GRACE: My life. What about my life? Say it.

GLORIA: *(trying to push it back but can't)* You buried not one child, but five! You have a grandson. Who are you to him? A woman he charges to run errands and cut wood. Haven't you ever asked yourself what your life's been for? Here you are a sick old woman, ravaged with pain, without a soul in the world to even care whether you live or – Grace, I – I think I'd better go home after all.

GRACE: I never have asked myself that question. What's my life been for – Maybe I should. I sure ain't left my mark on much o' nothin'.

GLORIA: Grace, I'm sorry.

GRACE: Why should you be sorry for ***my*** miserable life? Got nothin' to do with you. I'd still like to know what you're doin' here, messin' with death. So, you lost a child.

GLORIA: Things happen . . . just happen. No rhyme, no reason. No one pulling the strings.

GRACE: I didn't say there was no reason.

GLORIA: Then what is it?

GRACE: How should I know? You accept each day as it comes. You don't question. Something like this happens, you start over. Good heavens, honey, either you do a thing or you don't. What other choice you got?

GLORIA: Oh, I've got choices. At least a few.

GRACE: Like what? *(slowly)* Oh. Oh, I see. That what this is, this volunteerin' you do? You here to try Death on for size 'fore you go off and kill yourself? Is that it? ***IS IT!***

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GLORIA: IT SHOULDN'T HAVE HAPPENED, GODDAMNIT! He was a brilliant, innocent boy with his whole life in front of him. You're the one with the faith, you tell me! What heavenly purpose was served by crushing his body and leaving it on my lap to die? All I want is an answer, Grace! One lousy reason! *(beat)* Except there is no answer, is there? I'm sorry, but whatever this – game is, I can't play it anymore!

GRACE: **(Pg 70)** *(long pause)* I don't like what's happenin' to me [either]. Ain't sayin' I'm doubtin'. Never doubted the good Lord one second o' my life. But you got me wonderin'. So many things. **(Pg 80)** You said it yourself. My life's been for nothin'! Absolutely nothin'! I'm an illiterate, backwards old woman! **(Pg 95)** *(freezes. takes a quick breath. her face goes blank)*

GLORIA: Grace? Grace, what is it?

GRACE: Pain . . . Goin' to be bad.

GLORIA: Grace?

GRACE: Oh, sweet Jesus.

GLORIA: *(reaching for the morphine in her bag)* Listen to me. Grace, this is morphine.

GRACE: NO! NO DRUGS! . . . Oh, sweet Jesus!

GLORIA: DAMNIT, GRACE! THERE IS NO REASON TO SUFFER LIKE THIS!

GRACE: I DON'T CARE! WON'T DO NO GOOD! *(Gloria holds Grace's mouth open, administers the drops. Grace pulls away)* Only fools believe in God. That's what I am. A FOOL! All the times I was cold and hungry and hurtin' and wantin' to run away from this miserable farm. But I though this is where God wanted me to be. Is that what you come here for? *(shouting)* TO TELL ME MY WHOLE LIFE WAS FOR NOTHIN'?!

GLORIA: Grace, please.

GRACE: Honey, I know I'm ignorant, but I've been happy in my ignorance! WHY COULDN'T YOU O' JUST LET ME DIE THAT WAY? I DON'T WANT YOU HERE! GET OUT! I'm an old woman. Why can't you understand that? Go on, get out of here! I don't need you!

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GLORIA: Yes, you do! *(beat)* Grace, I'll probably never believe in the same things you do. But you've shown me . . . that it might be possible to believe in something again. Are you listening to me? Grace?

GRACE: *(a little surprised)* Pain's goin' away. It's that morphine ain't it? *(Gloria nods)* **(Pg 101)** *(thinking, then speaks)* I think that's all God wants any of us to do . . . hold on to each other with all our might. *(tears)* Look at me, cryin' like a baby! *(long pause)* **(Pg 102)** If I take a nap, you think I'll wake up? *(Gloria's eyes fill with tears)* **(Pg 103)** You cryin', honey? Why?

GLORIA: I don't know.

GRACE: *(holding out her hand)* Maybe you're grievin' for me already . . . That's what this is, this messin' with death you do. You think if you stop grievin' you'll finally have to let go of your little boy.

GLORIA: *(takes Grace's hand)* I loved him so much, Grace.

GRACE: 'Course you did. But, honey, it wasn't death tied you and that little boy together, it was life. *(closes her eyes and falls asleep)*

GLORIA: *(kneels by her side, holding her hand; sings softly)* "He will give me grace and glory, and go with me all the way."*

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AWARD HISTORY

MN State Qualifier

Music and Lyrics to "Where He Leads Me" can be found here:
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=iBX6AMp9AXM

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